Chapter 16: Taking Flight

"Okay, so why are we at the airport?" Noah asked.
"Date night," I answered calmly.
"Yeah, I got that part, but why the airport? Did you book us a flight somewhere or something?"
"Yeah, something like that. You'll see, you'll like it," I told him, taking us through the field base and out to the parking lot. We walked past the endless rows of planes, all adorned with different artwork and tail numbers. We finally reached mine – a standard Cessna 172 Skyhawk, wrapped in stripes of various blue tints. On the tail, C-GJTX was written in bold, black letters. I wasn't Cameron or the infamous cyber assassin in the sky. I was just a callsign and a bunch of seemingly random letters. That's the beauty of it. Nobody knew who I was.
"Wow…" he said, staring in amazement, his jaw glued open.
"How about we get started with the pre-flight?"
"No way…" he said, still just as wide-eyed as before.
"Yes way," I answered. I started looking over all the usual things I needed to check before taking off.
"You can fly a plane? Since when?"
"About grade 11," I answered, continuing around the aircraft. "My parents bought this a long time ago and I sort of inherited it after moving here. She's… my baby."
"Why didn't you tell me?"
"You're not the only one to have secrets, Noah. I'm not just a nerd here. I'm in control. I usually keep it private, but I'm ready to share it with you. I want you to see it. I want us to share it."
"You're… serious?"
"Yeah. Why else would I bring you here?" I opened the passenger side door and said, "Get in jock boy, we're going flying." Still in awe about the fact that I knew how to fly a plane – let alone owned one – he slowly got into the seat. I fastened his seatbelt for him and closed the door. I walked around to the other side, checking the propeller in the front as I went by it, and sat in the pilot's seat.

"Cameron… your nerd is showing," he said, watching me start to fill in my logbook. He nudged me with his arm – he was poking fun at me.
"Ha, ha," I responded, the sarcasm clear in my voice. "If you think this is nerdy, just wait until we're in the air. It gets better."
"You know, you look like you really belong here," he said, his face sporting a soft, loving smile. He turned from the teasing jock to the serious but loving boyfriend I love.
"Sometimes, this is the only place I do belong… especially in high school. I often went flying to escape the constant torment of being a nerd. It's the only thing that I could use to relax: the sky's always there, just waiting for you to explore it. It won't make fun of you or judge you." I answered. I breathed for a few seconds, taking in the all too familiar air of the cockpit, letting it calm me. "You were right – I need to get away after what went on during that dinner. We both do. Just being here calms me down. You do too. I'm glad you're here with me in one of my favorite places to be. It's a two-for-one: date night with the boy I love, plus a well-deserved retreat. Here, put this on," I said, handing him the second headset.

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I turned on the master power, and the avionics unit sprang to life. The attitude indicator showed we were fully level. The map showed exactly where we were: CWFC, the airport's code, underneath its dot. I tuned the radio to the weather report frequency, and after a brief pause, we both heard the robotic voice start listing information:

Waterloo Flying Club information Echo: issued zero-two-zero-zero Zulu.
Wind two-four-zero at seven.
Visibility one-zero.
Temperature one-niner, dew point zero-five.
Sky conditions: two-thousand clear, three-thousand scattered, four-thousand broken.
Altimeter three-zero-zero-six.
IFR approach ILS or visual, expect runway two-six.
Advise on initial contact information Echo.

"Weather seems good – decent visibility and ceilings," I said as I set up the primary flight display.
"Does any of that really matter?"
"Absolutely – the weather can change how I fly. In certain conditions, I need to rely on instruments, but not today. We're fully visual. Now… help me out with something, what's my callsign?" I asked.
"I don't know anything about flying… how should I know?"
"Well… you did answer the question at trivia night. This is a Cessna 172, so what's my callsign?"
"Oh! Right… You can use Skyhawk!"
"That's right – I usually do; it just sounds cooler."

I turned on the engine, tuned the radio to the ground control frequency, and pressed the button in the corner of my yoke. "Flying Club ground, Skyhawk Charlie Golf Juliet Tango X-ray, request taxi to runway two-six with information Echo," I said somewhat quickly and full of confidence.
"Skyhawk Juliet Tango X-Ray, Flying Club ground, taxi to runway two-six via Alpha One, cross one-seven at Charlie. Contact tower, one-two-one point niner."
"Taxi via Alpha One, cross one-seven at Charlie, and will contact tower when ready for departure. Skyhawk Juliet Tango X-ray."
I followed the controller's instructions to get us to the runway hold-short point. I switched to the tower frequency and keyed up again. "Flying Club tower, Skyhawk Charlie Golf Juliet Tango X-ray holding short of runway two-six, ready for takeoff with information Echo."
A few seconds of static passed, then I heard the tower respond, "Skyhawk Juliet Tango X-ray, Flying Club tower, runway two-six cleared for take-off."
"Cleared for take-off, runway two-six, Skyhawk Juliet Tango X-Ray, thank you." I responded.
"That's us – ready?" I asked Noah.
"So ready! Let's do this!"
I pushed in the throttle as far as it would go. The engine roared at full speed as we rolled onto the runway. We quickly reached 20 knots, then 40. When we eventually hit around 55 knots, one word came to mind: *rotate*. I slowly pulled the yoke towards me until I felt the front tire lift off the ground, followed by the two in the back. Just like that, we were in the air… one of my favourite places to be, just like I told him. *Positive climb*, I thought as I got us to altitude.

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Noah's eyes stayed glued to his window, staring outside at the early nighttime cityscape. After about ten minutes of flying, I wanted to show him something even better. "Hey – want to see something cool?" I asked.
"Always," Noah answered, voice soft.
"Flying Club tower, Skyhawk Juliet Tango X-ray, request VFR on top for a brief scenic climb."
"Skyhawk Juliet Tango X-ray, Flying Club tower, VFR on top approved. Climb and maintain three-thousand-five-hundred, report descent."
"VFR on top approved, will climb and maintain three-thousand-five-hundred and will report descent, Skyhawk Juliet Tango X-ray," I replied. "This is my favourite. Just… watch out the window," I told Noah, slowly bringing the plane to our assigned altitude.
"Wow… We're in the clouds…" he said as we crossed the boundary.
"Cool, right? We're all alone here. There's nobody else in this airspace. It's all ours. I'll do you one even better. Put your hands on the yoke in front of you, and your feet on the pedals. Don't move – just feel." His hands nervously clutched his yoke; his feet slowly and softly landed on the pedals. He closed his eyes and sat frozen, just feeling how I adjusted the controls. After a few seconds, he seemed to pick up on the flow of the small movements I was making. "Ready to try it?" I asked him.
He snapped his eyes open. His hands came away from his yoke. "Me? Fly your plane? I don't know how to fly!" he panicked.
"You might not, but I do – and as long as I can control the plane if something happens, I'm comfortable letting you try it. I trust you. But if I say 'my controls', you freeze. Instantly. Got it?"
"Um… okay, I guess," he answered.
"So, what do you say? Want to give it a shot?"
"Sure, tell me what to do," he answered, excited yet still hesitant and unsure of his ability.
"Start by trying to maintain our altitude. Pull the yoke towards you to go up, push it away from you to go down. Make slow, gentle adjustments – it's sensitive, and this is real life, not a video game," I told him. I kept my fingers lightly wrapped around my yoke, giving him the freedom to feel the plane respond to his movements, but ready to take control if I needed to.
"So… like this…" he said, slowly pushing back. Out the window, the nose dipped slightly down.
"Just like that, now try the other way – level us out." He pulled back lightly and I told him "That's it, good. Now how about a small turn? Twist it in the direction you want to go. I'll handle the pedals. Just feel the moment, feel the movements… That's it… good."

The engine hummed around us, the radio silent. The clouds gave Noah's face a cute orangey glow in the warm October sunset. Since Noah was doing well with the controls, I closed my eyes for a second. I took a slow, deep breath, embracing the white noise of the engine and the solitude of being above the clouds, away from the rest of the world. I finally seemed to release all the anger from the dinner. Flying always did have that effect on me. When I opened my eyes, Noah was still attentively guiding the plane, but I caught him taking the odd glance at me. His face wore the same gentle smile he had before.
"What?" I asked, smiling and laughing slightly.
"Nothing…" he started, pausing for a second. "You just… look so happy." His hand found mine, like it just knew where to go, our fingers slipping together perfectly. He started to lean in close.
"I love seeing you happy," he whispered.

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“And I love you being here,” I whispered back, inching closer to him and squeezing his hand. He leaned in closer, his forehead softly resting on mine. I turned my head, inviting him to do what I knew he wanted. He kissed me, his hand softly caressing my head. Slow. Careful. Ever so passionate. Just like always. It made me feel even better than flying alone ever could. Shortly after, he leaned back, his eyes staring out the window in amazement, one hand on the yoke, the other still glued to mine. I wouldn’t have it any other way. For the first time, flying wasn’t just an escape. It was still an escape, but this time, it was *also* bringing someone with me. It was connecting with someone I loved.

We spent about another twenty minutes above the clouds before the sky turned darker. I *am* night rated, but I never liked flying at night if I could avoid it. “Time to descend. Want to make the call?” I asked.
“I can’t talk to the tower! What would I even say?” he panicked once again.
“It’s just another conversation: push your button and say who we are, who you’re trying to talk to, and what we want. Then, wait for them to answer. They will always answer.”
“Okay, I guess I can try,” he said, his voice nervous. He pressed the button and started, his voice slow and full of a sharp anxiousness, “Flying Club tower, Skyhawk… uh… Juliet Tango X-ray, ready for descent.”
Static once again filled our headsets, before the controller responded, “Skyhawk Juliet Tango X-ray, Flying Club tower, ident and descend to two thousand, maintain VFR.”
“Wow…” he started in surprise, “they… answered me. Now what?”
“Read it back, press that button, and slowly bring us down until that big number says 2,000.”
“Ident and descend to two thousand, maintaining VFR,” he said, his voice quicker and ever so slightly more confident.
“Don’t forget our callsign – always identify yourself.”
“Skyhawk Juliet Tango X-ray,” he said quickly. “What does all of that mean?” he asked.
“Ident is short for identify. When you pressed the button, the plane sent a signal to the radar, allowing the controller to know which image is ours by making it bigger on their screen.”
“What about the last bit, ‘maintain VFR?’”
“VFR stands for visual flight rules. Basically, I need to see where I’m going and what’s around me. Otherwise, I have to use IFR – instrument flight rules, where the plane’s navigation systems guide it.”

He slowly pushed the yoke back and got us to our newly assigned altitude. From two thousand feet above, the lights that kept the city lit seemed insignificant. They looked like small dots lighting up the night sky. “Nice,” I said, adjusting the trim to stay level.
“Wow… I just… flew a plane…” he said slowly.
“You did great – now, let’s look around a bit. Take it where you want.”
“Wait – I can keep going? I can control it?”
“I’m still in control of the plane; you’re just guiding the view.”
He took us into city center, spotting our university football field from the air. I showed him the rest of University Ave – where the other two major universities in our city were. We saw the deep purple end zones of one of their football fields, and the large, black letters on the other’s. Who would have thought three rival universities would all be within three blocks of each other? We looked around for about another hour, both of us enjoying each other’s company, before I

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brought him back towards the airport. Suddenly, the nose veered right. “What’s happening? I didn’t do anything!”
“The autopilot wants us to follow the approach path. I’ll turn it off. It’s time for us to land,” I said, pressing the autopilot disconnect. The annoying beep of the warning signal started loudly ringing in my ear. I silenced it with the press of another button.
“Watch the runway,” I said as the plane came closer to the airport. “My controls,” I said. He threw his hands in the air as I took control of the plane. I pressed my transmit button again and asked, “Flying Club tower, Skyhawk Juliet Tango X-ray, request runway lights full intensity.”
“Skyhawk Juliet Tango X-ray, request received, one moment.” Within a few seconds, the lights guiding me to the runway bloomed to their highest brightness, piercing through the now dark night sky. “Skyhawk Juliet Tango X-ray, runway lights set to full intensity.”
“Woah… you can just ask them to do that?”
“Of course… I’ve got to see where I’m landing. They sometimes forget to turn the lights up or don’t realize it’s dark enough for it,” I said. “Flying Club tower, Skyhawk Juliet Tango X-ray, three miles west on downwind, request visual approach, full-stop runway two-six.”
“Skyhawk Juliet Tango X-ray, Flying Club tower, turn left base, runway two-six cleared for the option.”
“Left base, cleared for the option, Skyhawk Juliet Tango X-ray.”
“Cleared for the option? What’s that mean?”
“It means we can do a full stop landing like I asked. We’re not taking off again. It’s their way to tell me it’s okay. It’s their *green*.” Noah’s face lit up with a knowing smirk and a soft shade of pink. He caught my reference to his safe words. I couldn’t help but smile at the sight of it.

I slowly brought the plane through the turn as instructed, the nose ever-so-slowly crossing the midfield. Shortly after the runway was centered in my window, I made the final turn. We were ready to enter the glide slope. Unfortunately for me, I wasn’t using instruments, so I had to make sure I was at the proper speed. I meticulously adjusted my pressure on the yoke and the throttle to keep the proper descent speed. Occasionally, I would catch Noah staring at me – my intense concentration, my fine movements. He stayed silent, but remained focused on me, just as focused as I was on the runway. He was trusting me to get us back to the ground safely. As we inched closer to the runway, I tensed up. If something went wrong here, we could get hurt, and I for sure did not want that. Noah’s hand once again found mine, his grip tense. “Flare,” I said quietly, starting to pull back the yoke. I felt the rear wheels touch the ground, coupled with the moderate shaking of our bodies as they did. The front wheel came next, with a slightly less intense shaking. “Nice and smooth,” I muttered. I instantly heard Noah let out a deep breath. His grip loosened, yet his hand lingered on mine. I finally relaxed. He was relieved – just as relieved as I was.

“Skyhawk Juliet Tango X-ray, exit left when able, contact ground one-two-zero point eight,” I heard come through my headset.
“Exit left when able, over to ground, Skyhawk Juliet Tango X-ray,” I immediately answered. I slowly took the next available exit. Once we cleared the hold short point, I turned the knob on the communications panel to the ground frequency and asked, “Flying Club ground, Skyhawk Charlie Golf Juliet Tango X-ray, clear of runway two-six on Bravo Three request taxi to general aviation parking.”

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A short burst of static filled the air, followed by “Skyhawk Juliet Tango X-ray, Flying Club ground, taxi to general aviation parking via Bravo and Alpha One, advise if marshalling required.”
“Taxi to general aviation parking via Bravo and Alpha One, marshalling appreciated. Skyhawk Juliet Tango X-ray.”

Back in the parking lot, I saw the marshaller waiting for us, the bright glow of his orange wands cutting through the dim ramp lights and the now purple-black night sky. I was lucky – I got a pull-through parking space. It’s a small luxury, but I always appreciate getting one at the end of a flight – especially after a longer one. I lined the plane up with him, intensely focusing on his signals. He slowly nudged us into position in the middle of the parking spot. Eventually, both wands slowly came above his head. I eased on the brakes until they crossed into an X. My feet tilted further forward on the pedals, slowly rolling the plane to a stop. I set the parking brake and gave him the signal. In return, he signaled for me to turn the engine off. I pulled the mixture and clicked the master power switch. The engine sputtered before falling completely silent. The sudden quiet felt different this time – almost unreal. I didn’t know why, but I thought Noah being here had something to do with it. He crouched briefly before touching the tips of his wands together. Then, he gave a salute with one wand – we were all clear. I gave him a thumb-up and a polite wave to thank him, took my headset off, and motioned for Noah to do the same.

Once the ground crew had all left the area, I got out of the plane, the silence still ringing in my ears. Right after me, Noah climbed out much more slowly, his hand momentarily stuck on the door as his shoes touched the ground. He walked over to my side of the plane, leaning against the door. He wasn’t ready for our moment to end. Neither was I – suddenly, I didn’t want to let it end. He was already staring at me, not saying a word. Just waiting. I stepped closer, his back brushing against the door behind him. I put one arm across his chest and lifted him slightly off the ground, his feet barely touching the pavement, and pinned him gently to the door. The metal let out a dull, hollow sound as I pressed him into it.
“Wh—What are you doing?” he asked softly. He didn’t move. He didn’t try to escape. If anything, he leaned into the little space left between us. He trusted me. I didn’t need to ask this time. Not because I stopped caring, but because after everything we’ve done – everything he’s taught me, I finally figured out how to feel it. The way his eyes stared at me. The way his breathing changed. The way he leaned into it. I started noticing all of it, and I knew he trusted me. I could suddenly read him.

His gaze looked down to see what I was doing. I lifted his head with my other hand, my fingers settling under his chin. Our eyes locked together. His breath caught. His eyes softened, full of curiosity and anticipation as he let me guide him. My hand moved from his chin to his waist. My eyes kept his attention. I wasn’t forcing him, just holding him in the moment. I felt his body give in. His shoulders relaxed. The tension in his arms disappeared. His hands quickly moved from the door to my face, holding me instead of holding himself up. He just melted into me, waiting for what would happen next. He wanted this just as much as I did.
“I’m just…” I started. I leaned more into his chest, bearing more of my weight on him. He let out a deep breath, almost like I squeezed it out of him. “Taking what’s mine,” I whispered in a deep and commanding voice. His breath became shallow. His body tremored. He leaned into me. I closed the distance and kissed him. Warm. Certain. Just as passionate as his. My hand at his

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waist steadied him as his body pressed into mine, my eyes keeping him exactly where I wanted him – where he wanted to be. He gave no resistance, asked no questions. He just followed, surrendering himself to the moment – and to me.

When I finally pulled back, letting my grip on him ease, I didn't move far. My hand stayed at his waist, brushing slightly, feeling his breath return to normal.
"You good?" I asked quietly.
He nodded quickly, voice soft. "Of course… I always am when you're in charge."
"It wasn't too much?"
"No – it was perfect. You know I love it when you're rough with me." His eyes locked onto mine, his fingers massaging my side. "But that…" he continued quietly. "That felt different. It wasn't just physical. You made it feel like you wanted *me*, not just my body. You made it romantic, not just sexual. That's what made it special. That's what made it perfect."
"I always loved you – right from the start. It wasn't just about the sex," I said, my voice unsteady.
"I know," he whispered. "That's always been crystal clear. But tonight… you dominated me without sex, and you let me have some freedom to explore. Somehow, that made it even more intimate than any of the sex we've had. You showed me that you can *truly* control me."
"That was the idea," I admitted softly. "I wanted to show you that I don't need sex to love you. That what we have is more than just sex. That I love *you*, not just your body. That I trust you as much as you trust me."
"Well… mission accomplished," he said slowly and quietly, leaning in to kiss me ever so softly. "You trusted me when I pinned you… and I didn't need to ask."
"And you trusted me to fly your plane when I didn't think I could."
We stayed there for a moment, not moving an inch, just holding each other. His hand lingered at my side, mine at his waist, the quiet between us calm, yet still warm. Finally, I gave him a small yet playful grin and asked, "Ready to step out of our little love bubble and back into the real world?"
He laughed softly, his fingers still brushing against me. "Yeah, I guess we should…"

I squeezed him gently, tilted my head, and asked, "So… how was my first *planned* date?"
"Cameron – that was…" he started, voice wandering. A slow smile crept its way across his face. "More than I expected, to say the least. You thought of everything, guided everything, and I let you. Completely. I loved every second."
I raised an eyebrow. "You… let me?" I asked, full of playful offense.
He chuckled again, shaking his head. "I didn't just let you. I trusted you… and honestly, you're much better than you were when we started."
"Better? I'm… still learning."
"No," he said quite firmly, bringing his hand to my cheek. "You're listening. You're watching. You're paying attention to what I'm *not* telling you. You're noticing my signals – what I like, what I respond to, when I trust you. Tonight, you… read me for the first time. That's huge for me – and it should be for you too. You've come so far, and I'm proud of you."
"I'm… glad you feel that way," I said as I felt my face get hotter and flushed. "I don't want to mess this up."
"You didn't. You made it better. You made it feel… natural – like you've always known how to be the dominant one."

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“Maybe… I’m finally getting this,” I said, letting out a breath I didn’t know I was holding.
“Oh, you definitely are…” he started, quietly laughing. “And I’m loving every second of letting you have control. You’ve got the confidence now, which makes everything we do… even more perfect.”
“Good, because I’m not done learning, which means you’re not done teaching me.” I stared directly into his eyes, and he stared right back. “Noah… you’re the best teacher I’ve ever had. I’m happy to be your student… as long as you keep letting me.”
“Always,” he said, leaning slightly closer and resting his head on my shoulder.

“What was your favourite part?”
He grinned and pushed into me a bit. “Honestly… I have to say it’s a tie.”
“Wow, you’re impossible,” I teased.
“Hear me out,” he said, soft but certain. “One part was letting me take control of our sightseeing. You trusted me to guide the plane, even though I’ve never done it before. I knew you were there if something went wrong, but… it felt… exciting. Safe, but thrilling at the same time.”
I felt a smile blossom on my face. I couldn’t help it. “And the second part?” I asked.
“Oh, definitely you pinning me to the door,” he started, eyes sparkling. “That was intense. I felt your control, your confidence, your dominant energy… but I wasn’t scared. You saw it – you *felt* that I trusted you completely. That I wanted you to take control. Remember our energy talk?” he asked. I slowly nodded, faintly remembering the moment. “Well… you built up the energy… then finally let the ball roll. If I had to pick an *absolute* favourite, that takes the cake for sure.”
“So… do you think we won?” I asked him.
“Definitely,” he answered, resting his head on my shoulder as we walked back through the field base.

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